

Such are the open beaches of the western and southern shores. The areas to the north and east are different. There are no open beaches, but extensive reed beds. There are thus no shore seines operating, and all nets and scoops are used in and near reeds, the most widespread gear in the areas is the trap. In the dry season one must walk about two miles across grassy plain, across mud flats, and finally onto the hardened mud of the shallow boat channels leading out into the lake. (In the rainy much of the plain is under water.) The fishermen live in the reed beds or on the islands and come to the selling points every one, two, or even four times. They sometimes keep the fish caught in garaga, baskets suspended in the reed beds or the fish are kept alive and fed, or else they dry or smoke them ready for sale. The reed beds of the north, especially, support a large fishing population. Fishermen live in small temporary structures, varying from small huts to tents or bents over reeds. These may be on dryer patches of reed beds or on the shore or on the zimbowera, which are made by piling up reeds and grass to the level of the water. Information so far received suggests that these are of fairly recent origin, perhaps even within the last decade or so, and

A typical scene on the open beaches of Lake Chilwa would be the one or more khoka teams operate their nets; canoes are paddled out into the water where the men shoot the net. Then begins the long, slow, rhythmic pulling of two tow ropes of the net by the team of labourers. The whole operation is shooting to the next takes about one and a half hours for the average team. The catch is collected from the bag of the net in buckets and tipped out mats; the fish are sorted out and put to dry or be smoked ready for sale. There are the other fishermen, two pulling a chirimira, others with simple nets (although many of these fish at night); gill nets are being reset or along the edges of the reed beds or farther out in open water. There is generally a spot where the boat channels emerge from the reed beds, where the reeds come to sell their fish to traders. All over the ground are of matemba drying in the sun, spread out for potential buyers (both local and duals and traders process the fish themselves). On some beaches are small long, low-eaved huts--with a series of open, smoky wood fires underneath. The fish are spread out to be cured. The traders rent smoking racks from the house for about 2/- for ever 1/- worth of fish and also pay for the water of the house for men, somewhat as water is paid for women. Some distance back from the beach are the temporary, though well-built and decorated, houses of the fishermen and in some places more permanent structures, too. There are the canteens, tea rooms, bars, and small shops, range of groceries and other common goods, all in the smallest weight materials as blankets and cotton materials.

Then there is the "head" (the English word is used), who is a deputy to the owner of the bwana. He is occasionally a relative, but the most important of him to be someone the owner can trust. Next in line is the "captain" of the team. Then comes the team of labourers and the cook, who does not monthly pay for the labourers is usually £2/10 but may be only £1 for the boys on the team. The captain may earn as much as 10/- more than the other and the head may earn as much as £4 a month. Labourers will normally season though some for only a few months at a time. The captain may be needed on the structure and changes in these companies (see Hill 1970).